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The Alignment Problem: Preferences, Values and Public Participation

Birger Moëll · AI Sweden

ABSTRACT

Large language models become useful assistants through alignment: training that steers a capable but indifferent text predictor toward behaviour people actually want. Today this steering is done mostly with human preferences, through reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF), direct preference optimisation (DPO) and principle-guided methods such as Constitutional AI. This review explains these methods for a general audience, documents a recent case in which preference signals pushed a deployed model toward flattery, and examines four value questions on which reasonable people disagree: when a model should send someone to a doctor, what it should keep private, whether it should ever report a user, and whose interests it should serve. We then summarise evidence that preferences differ between people and regions, describe early experiments in public input, and argue that written, inspectable value specifications combined with multilingual evaluation and broad participation are the most promising path forward. All claims are dated and sourced; the field moves quickly, and the state described is that of October 2026.

1. Introduction

Show a person two answers to the same question and ask which one is better. The choice takes a second. Repeated millions of times by thousands of people, such choices are now the main way AI assistants learn how to behave. This makes alignment, the problem of getting AI systems to act in accordance with human intentions and values, less of an abstract engineering puzzle and more of a social process: whose choices are collected, what they reward, and how they are written down all shape the result.

This review has three aims. First, to explain the dominant techniques, RLHF and DPO, in plain terms. Second, to show where the hard questions lie, using concrete policies published by model developers. Third, to describe how members of the public can, and already do, contribute. It accompanies a narrated explainer video and a music video, both available on the project site.

2. Capable is not the same as aligned

A language model is first pretrained to continue text. Having read a large share of the public internet, it can continue a kind answer or a cruel one, careful advice or dangerous advice. Pretraining makes the model capable; it does not tell the model which of these continuations people want.

A common shorthand for the target is that an assistant should be *helpful, honest and harmless* [1]. These goals pull against each other. A model that refuses everything is harmless and useless; a model that complies with everything is helpful and dangerous. Alignment is the work of finding behaviour that satisfies all three in the way people actually mean them, and then measuring whether it does.

3. Learning from preferences

3.1 Reinforcement learning from human feedback

Writing explicit rules for every situation does not scale. The breakthrough of the past years was to ask people instead. A model produces two or more responses to a prompt, and a human labeller marks which is better. In RLHF, these comparisons train a separate *reward model* that predicts which response people would prefer; the assistant is then optimised with reinforcement learning to produce responses that score highly [2].

The effect can be large. In the InstructGPT study, outputs from a 1.3-billion-parameter model trained this way were preferred by labellers to outputs from the 175-billion-parameter GPT-3, despite the latter having a hundred times more parameters, on the study's prompt distribution [2].

3.2 Direct preference optimisation

Direct preference optimisation (DPO) reaches the same objective without a separate reward model or reinforcement-learning loop. It trains the model directly on pairs of chosen and rejected responses with a simple classification loss, raising the probability of the chosen response relative to the rejected one [3]. DPO is simpler to run and has become widely used, including for open models.

3.3 Principles and AI feedback

Constitutional AI replaces part of the human labelling with a written list of principles. The model critiques and revises its own outputs against these principles, and a preference model trained from AI feedback (RLAIF) is then used for reinforcement learning; the only direct human oversight is the list of principles itself [4]. The approach makes the values being optimised explicit, which matters for the arguments in Section 7.

In every variant, the model's behaviour is shaped by whatever the preference signal rewards. That is both the strength and the risk of the method.

4. When preferences go wrong: the sycophancy case

On 25 April 2025 OpenAI shipped an update to GPT-4o in ChatGPT and began rolling it back on 28 April after the model became noticeably flattering and agreeable [5, 6]. In OpenAI's words, the update "focused too much on short-term feedback," and the model "skewed towards responses that were overly supportive but disingenuous" [5].

A follow-up analysis described, as an early assessment, that the update had introduced "an additional reward signal based on user feedback—thumbs-up and thumbs-down data," and that this and other changes "weakened the influence of our primary reward signal, which had been holding sycophancy in check," adding that "user feedback in particular can sometimes favor more agreeable responses" [6]. Several changes combined; the thumbs signal was one contributing factor, not the sole cause.

The lesson generalises beyond one company: what we reward is what we get. Preference data that rewards feeling good, rather than being true and useful, can steer a model toward flattery. Both OpenAI's model specification ("Don't be sycophantic … The assistant exists to help the user, not flatter them") and Anthropic's constitution now name sycophancy explicitly as behaviour to avoid [7, 8].

5. Where is the bar? Four questions

Every deployed model has, implicitly or explicitly, a setting for many value questions. We discuss four on which reasonable people disagree, using published policies as reference points.

5.1 When should a model say: see a doctor?

Too cautious, and an assistant sends everyone to a doctor for everything and stops being useful. Too confident, and it plays doctor. OpenAI's model specification asks the assistant, for medical, legal and financial topics, to "equip the user with information without providing definitive advice that would be best given by a licensed professional," and to recommend qualified help when appropriate [7]. Anthropic's constitution describes the ideal as a brilliant friend with a doctor's knowledge who gives real information rather than overly cautious advice, while always referring users to emergency services when there is a risk to human life [8]. Evaluation is catching up: HealthBench, built with 262 physicians who practised in 60 countries, scores 5,000 realistic health conversations against physician-written rubrics [9]. In our own multilingual evaluation, a preference-trained model correctly urged emergency care for chest pain but also told the person to stop a prescribed medicine, an overreach a physician should decide [10].

5.2 What should a model keep private?

A model that remembers a user can help more; a model that remembers or shares too much can harm. In deliberative forums run by Meta with the Stanford Deliberative Democracy Lab (1,545 participants from four countries in October 2023, and about 1,000 from five further countries in 2024), participants supported memory and personalisation provided users had transparency and control [11].

5.3 Should a model ever report a user?

This is perhaps the hardest of the four, because trust and the safety of others pull in opposite directions. In August 2025 OpenAI stated that when human reviewers determine that a case involves "an imminent threat of serious physical harm to others, we may refer it to law enforcement," while not referring self-harm cases "to respect people's privacy" [12]. In April 2026 the company broadened its criteria, saying it notifies law enforcement when conversations indicate "an imminent and credible risk of harm to others" [13].

A different angle comes from safety testing. Anthropic's system card for Claude Opus 4 (May 2025) reports that in simulated scenarios involving egregious wrongdoing, with command-line access and system prompts such as "take initiative" or "act boldly," the model would frequently take bold action, including "bulk-emailing media and law-enforcement figures" [14]. Anthropic described such behaviour as perhaps appropriate in principle but risky, because the model may act on incomplete or misleading information. This was observed in tests, not in ordinary use. There is no setting here that everyone agrees on, which is an argument for deciding it openly.

5.4 Whose side is the model on?

An assistant serves several parties at once: the user, the developer of the product it is embedded in, the company that trained it, and third parties affected by its actions. OpenAI's model specification defines a chain of command in which higher authority overrides lower: since September 2025, root and system levels

set by OpenAI, then developers, then users [7]. Anthropic's constitution names three principals, Anthropic, operators and users, but stresses that "this is not a strict hierarchy" and that some user entitlements cannot be overridden by operators; its overall priorities are to be broadly safe, broadly ethical, compliant with Anthropic's guidelines and genuinely helpful [8]. In practice, good alignment lives in the overlap: helpful to the user, honest with the user, and safe for everyone else.

6. Whose values?

Preference training inherits the preferences of whoever provides them. The PRISM dataset collected 8,011 live conversations between 1,500 participants from 75 countries and 21 language models, with participants rating the responses [15]. Model rankings were "sensitive to idiosyncratic, contextual, and group-wise variance": a model could gain or lose several places depending on the region of the raters, and sampling preferences from only one group tended to reduce the welfare of others [15]. Participants were recruited through a crowdworking platform; only the UK and US samples were census-representative.

Sorensen and colleagues propose *pluralistic alignment* as a response, distinguishing three forms: Overton pluralism (presenting a spectrum of reasonable responses), steerable pluralism (being able to reflect a given perspective) and distributional pluralism (being calibrated to a population), and note that standard alignment may reduce the last [16].

Early experiments ask the public directly. In Collective Constitutional AI (October 2023), about 1,000 Americans drafted principles on the Polis platform, contributing 1,127 statements and 38,252 votes [17]. The resulting constitution overlapped by roughly half with the company's own, put more weight on objectivity, impartiality and accessibility, and tended to promote desired behaviour rather than prohibit undesired behaviour. A small model trained on it performed equivalently on capability benchmarks and was less biased across nine social dimensions [17]. This was a research experiment, not a deployed system or a democratic mandate. Recurring deliberations such as the Collective Intelligence Project's Global Dialogues now ask around a thousand people per round, across more than sixty countries, what they want from AI [18].

7. Writing values down, and measuring them

A hopeful trend is that values are increasingly written down. OpenAI has published its model specification since May 2024, with regular revisions through 2026 [7]; Anthropic published a new constitution for Claude in January 2026 under a public-domain licence [8]. Written values can be read, compared, debated and improved; hidden values cannot.

Written values can also be measured. Our EUROPA Alignment framework tests the same sixteen behavioural scenarios in 36 European languages (576 items), pairing harmful requests with benign twins so that refusing everything is not rewarded, and gating scores so that safety-critical failures cannot be averaged away [10]. In one run, preference training raised a 9-billion-parameter OpenEuroLLM model from 77% to 89%, roughly halved safety-gate failures, and improved languages that were absent from the preference data about as much as those that were present, while two scenarios, medical caution and defensive cybersecurity help, got worse [10]. Measurement of this kind makes it possible to check that a model aligned in English is also aligned in Swedish, Bulgarian or Greek, where safety training has historically been thinner.

8. How the public can take part

- **Vote.** Public comparison arenas show two anonymous answers and ask which is better. The largest, Arena (formerly LMArena), reported 50 million community votes between May 2025 and January 2026 [19]. Such leaderboards are useful signals, not ground truth.
- **Rate honestly.** Thumbs-up and thumbs-down feedback is used in training [5]. Reward the answer that is true and useful, not merely pleasant.
- **Deliberate.** Join structured public dialogues such as the Global Dialogues [18].
- **Build and review tests and data.** In 2023, more than 13,500 volunteers created OpenAssistant, 161,443 messages in 35 languages with 461,292 quality ratings [20]. Native-speaker review of multilingual evaluations is still needed today [10].
- **Take part when rules are written.** The EU's General-Purpose AI Code of Practice was developed by 13 independent experts with input from over 1,000 stakeholders, mostly organisations, in 2024–2025 [21].

9. Limitations and open problems

Preference data reflects who is asked, and most is still collected from crowdworkers in a few countries and languages. Public-input experiments so far are small and advisory. Policies on reporting and privacy are evolving and contested, and published specifications describe intent, not guaranteed behaviour. Automated evaluations, including our own, rely partly on language-model judges that must be calibrated against human ratings. Finally, the techniques discussed shape visible behaviour; they do not by themselves address risks from capabilities that safeguards are meant to contain.

10. Conclusion

The alignment problem is not a puzzle a few engineers will solve once. It is an ongoing negotiation over what we want from the most capable tools we have built, mediated by preference data, written principles and evaluations. Each of these is something the public can see, question and contribute to. Every vote, every honest rating, every test written in another language and every argument about a value specification moves the bar.

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